

WORDS OF POWER

magical handbooks



▲ The magic of Solomon

This is a page from *The Magical Treatise of Solomon*, which, it is claimed, contains instructions on magic given by King Solomon to his son Rehoboam. The earliest versions of this title date to the 14th century. Its subtitle is “The Art of Hygromancy”—that is, divining by water.

The medieval period saw the creation of many handbooks of magic, which later came to be called grimoires, from the French *grammaire* (grammar). Today they are sometimes referred to as Books of Shadows, a term first used for Wiccan grimoires.

The medieval Christian Church viewed these handbooks as dealing with either “natural” or “demonic” magic. Church leaders defined natural magic, such as harnessing the occult power of herbs for healing, as a legitimate use of the marvels of nature created by God, but they argued that demonic magic, such as necromancy, came from the Devil.

Nevertheless, of the texts that survive in Europe, the clergy were the main writers on both kinds of magic.

Ancient sources

Medieval European handbooks on magic were mostly written in Latin, the international language of scholars at the time. Some of them had originally been composed by Islamic scholars in Arabic, or by Jewish scholars in Hebrew. In order to give their texts authenticity, authors often asserted that they were derived from much older sources, or written by ancient figures who had access to magical secrets that were lost during the spread of Christianity and

Islam. It was even better if the figure was from the Bible, as this suggested the book had religious legitimacy. Several books of magic made rhetorical claims to be based on the writings of King Solomon, while 15th-century German abbot Trithemius owned a book supposedly written by Simon Magus (also known as Simon the Magician), who appears in the New Testament performing miracles, though Simon was denounced by Church leaders as a heretic whose magic had demonic origins.

► Wisdom by incantation

These red diagrams from a copy of the *Ars notoria* show the order of some of its incantations (in small black script), which consist of prayers and exotic names. If spoken correctly, these were believed to unlock the power of knowledge.

“This is the book by which anyone at all can be saved and be led forth into eternal life ...”

THE SWORN BOOK OF HONORIUS, 13TH CENTURY

